

SAMPLES FOR PD

SAMPLE B

SECTION A

Question 1a

We used semi-structured interviews to find out how much time students were on social media and how that affected their self-esteem. We designed an interview schedule with mainly open-ended questions, but with a few more specific ones and interviewed several of our colleagues and some from the younger years as well. They all signed an informed consent form and afterwards we warned them that we had recorded them, but they were all happy with that.

The interview times varied, as some people were happy to talk a lot, but others were not. We transcribed our recordings and found that those who spent most time on social media had lower self-esteem, which is what we expected to find. Anyone who asked was allowed to see the transcripts, which we had made anonymous.

Question 1b

There was little bias in our semi-structured interviews, as most of the questions were open-ended. Our interviewees were also open-minded about the use of social media, as all of them used it themselves, so there was not much researcher bias. However, there may have been some social desirability bias on the part of the interviewees, as some of their answers to the time spent on social media were much lower than we would have expected. The opposite was true when they answered questions about their own self-esteem. So this may have biased our results.

Finally, there may have been some confirmation bias when we interpreted the results, as we were all expecting them to show a strong negative correlation between time spent on social media sites and levels of self-esteem and may have ignored findings that did not show that

Question 1c

Interviews, like our semi-structured interview that we used to find out how time spent on social media affected self-esteem, are a qualitative research method. As such they are quite different from quantitative experimental methods. Interviews are looking for participants' subjective experiences and not to try and generalize these findings beyond a small target population, or in some cases even beyond the participants in the research.

Interviews are conducted in natural settings (ours was in our school library) and with a relaxed atmosphere and can be quite small-scale – we only had ten participants and generated recordings – but that was still a lot of data to analyse.

Experiments are a quantitative research method. They are conducted in controlled surroundings, often in a lab and usually have a hypothesis to test by manipulating an independent variable and finding out its effect on a controlled variable. They are not good for finding out feelings like self-esteem as they have no ecological validity.

The only similarity I can see is that they both need participants and both need to maintain ethical standards.

Question 1d

Our topic was how being on social media affected self-esteem. The best way to do this would be by a covert participant observation. It would be a naturalistic observation, in places and at times that our colleagues and hopefully some younger students were on social media. We would sit with them at break and lunchtime and maybe try and chat a bit during the investigation about how much time we ourselves spent on social media, and how we used filters to change our images.

We would keep secret notes on our phones of how long our colleagues seemed to spend. This would be an opportunity sample of people we knew and who would be comfortable with us sitting with them. We would write up the notes afterwards, maintaining anonymity. We wouldn't tell them we were keeping notes or observing them until we decided we had enough data for our observation results, and then we would do a debriefing.

SECTION B

Question 2

Two concepts that are important are **causality and responsibility**. Causality is usually shown in a true experiment by manipulating an IV and measuring its effect on the DV while keeping all other variables constant (controlled). In this study, the results on the fake IQ test were manipulated so one group of men was told they were genius and the other group was told they were right off the bottom of the scale. This was assumed (rightly or wrongly) to affect their self-esteem (the DV) which was operationalized as how well they engaged in conversation with an attractive woman in the waiting room afterwards. This is not a good way of measuring self-esteem, in my opinion.

It could also cause stress, which is where responsibility comes in. The men may not have been the type to want to talk to a strange woman in a public place and they may have felt embarrassed if trying to do so, which causes psychological harm, which is unethical. Psychological harm could also have been caused to the men told they had very low marks, especially if they cared about that sort of thing. There was also no mention of any informed consent or debriefing, and participants were paid for their participation, which is also unethical. This is not a responsible study.